

Rouzhi Liang

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Latest version available [here](#)

Academic Appointments

Postdoctoral Researcher, Southern Methodist University

2026 - Present

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, Southern Methodist University 2026

M.A. in Economics, Southern Methodist University 2022

M.S. in Economics, University of Wisconsin-Madison 2018

B.A. in Economics, Beihang University 2016

Research Fields

Primary: Macroeconomics and Economic Growth

Secondary: Family Economics, Inequality and Culture

Working Papers

Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship: The Intergenerational Transmission of Economic Inequality (*Job Market Paper*) ([PDF](#))

* Winner of the SEA 2024 Graduate Student Award

This paper studies how endogenous fertility and bequest decisions shape the intergenerational transmission of entrepreneurship and inequality in the presence of financial frictions. I develop and quantify an overlapping-generations model in which parents jointly choose fertility and bequests, while children make occupational choices subject to borrowing constraints. The model is calibrated to match evidence from the US PSID on family structure, wealth, income, and entrepreneurship. Eliminating financial frictions raises steady-state income per capita by 13 percent but reduces the entrepreneurship rate and increases income inequality. Improved credit access reallocates capital toward more productive firms, allowing them to expand while inducing less productive entrepreneurs to become workers. Their expansion raises the equilibrium return on capital, disproportionately benefiting wealthier households because they hold substantially more financial wealth.

Individualism, Innovation and Economic Development: Evidence from Cross-Country and Within-U.S. Analyses ([PDF](#))

This paper examines the impact of individualism on innovation and economic development over time, both across countries and within the US. At the country level, I extend the literature by expanding the time scope and incorporating more controls while employing instrumental variables. However, results vary across specifications. Then I turn to the within-US analysis and construct time-varying individualism measures at the county group level using ancestry ratios and country-level individualism indexes. Contrary to the existing literature, I find that individualism has a negative or insignificant influence on innovation and economic development. These findings raise new questions about how cultural traits may interact with institutions.

Research in Progress

Finance, Demographic Transition, and Structural Change

Multiple Entrepreneurial Talent Misallocation joint with [Javier Gonzalez](#)

Culture, Mobility, and Economic Growth joint with Ömer Özak and Chih Ming Tan

Research Experience

Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Wookun Kim	2020
- Collected and cleaned NASA satellite-based pollution data using Python and QGIS - Built geospatial datasets for empirical research in environmental economics - Demonstrated ability in remote sensing and spatial data visualization	
Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Michael Sposi	2022
- Collected global trade datasets and analyzed the data using Stata - Strengthened skills in data cleaning and macroeconomic analysis	
Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Daniel L. Millimet	2024
- Cleaned Census data and replicated county-level trade shock data - Demonstrated proficiency in managing complex datasets and multiple projects	
Graduate Research Assistant for Dr. Lones Smith and Dr. Lorenzo Magnolfi	2018-2019
- Use expected loss as price for lottery to estimate the supply and demand curve. - Work on the lotteries of Mega Ball and China's 7 Lucky Lottery.	

Teaching Experience

Southern Methodist University	
Instructor: Intermediate Macroeconomics	Summer 2023
Teaching Assistant:	
Macroeconomic Theory I (Ph.D.-level)	Fall 2023
Microeconomic Theory I (Ph.D.-level)	Fall 2021
Microeconomic Theory II (Ph.D.-level)	Spring 2021
Strategic Behavior (Master-level)	Fall 2019; Spring 2020; Spring 2021
Economic Analysis I (Master-level)	Fall 2019
Economic Analysis II (Master-level)	Spring 2020
International Macroeconomic Theory and Policy (Undergraduate-level)	Spring 2020; Spring 2023
Intermediate Microeconomics (Undergraduate-level)	Spring 2020

Conference and Seminar Presentations

Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting	2025
<i>Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship</i>	
<i>Individualism and Innovation: Unraveling Culture's Influence Across Time</i>	
North Texas Economics Conference	2025
<i>Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship</i>	
Three Minute Thesis Competition Finalist	2025
<i>Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship</i>	
Southern Methodist University Brown Bag Seminar	2025
<i>Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship</i>	
Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting	2024
<i>Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship</i> (Graduate Student Award)	
Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting	2023
<i>Individualism and Innovation: Unraveling Culture's Influence Across Time</i>	
SMU Research and Innovation Week	2023
<i>Bequests, Fertility, and Barriers to Entrepreneurship</i> (Poster Presentation)	

Skills

Programming	Python, Stata, QGIS, L ^A T _E X
Language	English (Fluent), Mandarin (Native)

Fellowships & Awards

Provost's Doctoral Candidacy Fellowship, Southern Methodist University	<i>2023–2026</i>
Graduate Student Award, Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting	<i>2024</i>
Graduate Fellowship, Southern Methodist University	<i>2019–2023</i>

Leadership & Outreach

SMU Department of Economics, Ph.D. Peer Mentor	<i>2022–2024</i>
SMU Dedman Graduate Student Assembly, Representative for the Economics Department	<i>2023–2025</i>
SMU Dedman Graduate Student Assembly, President	<i>2025–2026</i>
Moody School Graduate Student Advisory Member from Dedman College	<i>2025–2026</i>

References

Dr. Ömer Özak (Advisor)

Associate Professor of Economics, Southern Methodist University

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Dr. Michael Sposi

Associate Professor and Director of Doctoral Studies, Southern Methodist University

Email: msposi@mail.smu.edu

Dr. Rocío Madera

Assistant Professor of Economics, Southern Methodist University

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